Shoftim 5783

In פרשת שופטים the pasuk says (17:11): עַל פִּי הַתּוֹרָה אֲשֶׁר יוֹרוּךָ וְעַל הַמִּשְׁפָּט אֲשֶׁר יֹאמְרוּ לְךָ תַּעֲשֶׂה לֹא תָסוּר מִן הַדָּבָר אֲשֶׁר יַגִּידוּ לְךָ יָמִין וּשְׂמֹאל. This is fairly straightforward, you should listen to the chachomim and you should not deviate from whatever they tell you, right or left. R' Yitzchak Berkovits quotes Rashi on the pasuk who says that you have to listen to the חכמים even if they tell you that right is left and left is right. R' Berkovits asks a question. If someone came to you and said to you, right is left and left is right, would you not respectfully say to him, "I'm sorry, I think you're making a mistake"? As Jews, we are trained to be independent thinkers. We are renowned for our critical eye. If so, how can we possibly understand what Rashi is saying to blindly follow the rabbis when we know that right is right and left is left?

R' Berkovits says that the answer is פשוט. Rashi does not come and tell you if the rabbis tell you east is west or west is east that you have to listen to them. He says right or left because right and left are subjective. Our perception of them depends on the way that we are facing. For instance, when facing someone else, your left is their right and your right is their left. Therefore, concludes R' Berkovits, Rashi is telling us that if the rabbis are telling you that right is left, make sure you turn around, because it's your perspective that's wrong.

In a similar vein, in an unrelated pasuk, right at the beginning of the פרשה, it says (16:21): לֹא תִטַּע לְךָ אֲשֵׁרָה כָּל עֵץ אֵצֶל מִזְבַּח ה' אֱלֹקֶיךָ אֲשֶׁר תַּעֲשֶׂה לָךְ - No trees are allowed to be planted in the בית המקדש. In the very next pasuk it says וְלֹא תָקִים לְךָ מַצֵּבָה אֲשֶׁר שָׂנֵא ה' אֱלֹקֶיךָ. So R' Moshe Feinstein brings an incredible insight into these two פסוקים, especially the pasuk regarding מצבה. What is a מצבה? A מצבה is a single slab of stone. We know today what a מצבה is, נעבעך, when someone passes away, we put up a מצבה, which means a single stone. What was the problem with a מצבה? The פשוט פשט, as well known in the גמרא, is that the גוים used to do their קרבנות and bring their עבודה זרה on a מצבה. R' Moshe adds to this and bring a pasuk (שמות כ׳:כ״ב): מִזְבַּח אֲבָנִים תַּעֲשֶׂה לִי - You should make a מזבח out of אֲבָנִים, out of stones. What's the difference between a מזבח of אבנים and a מצבה? A מצבה is one stone. A מזבח is a number of stones. R' Moshe says a מצבה represents one spot. You've done one thing; you're stuck in that one spot. אבנים represents steps. אבנים can represent a series of אבנים, a series of steps where you can move. Our job in our life is to constantly strive to move upward. A מצבה means stationary, standing still. After a person passes away, we build a מצבה because that's as far as he got. This is his level of accomplishment, whatever he accomplished, more or less, hopefully more, is what he did. The מצבה represents completion of accomplishment, and אבנים represent ongoing creativity. In the same vein, the gemara (ברכות סד ע״א) bring down what's the difference between לֵךְ לשלום and לֵךְ בשלום? When a person says to somebody לֵךְ בשלום, it's not a good thing. לֵךְ בשלום means that that's it, you have completed your job. That's not said to a living person. What you tell a living person is לֵךְ לשלום which means keep on trucking. A מצבה means end. It's all over. מצבה is what cemeteries are full of. מזבח מאבנים is what we're working on, our עבודת השם, which is ongoing.

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